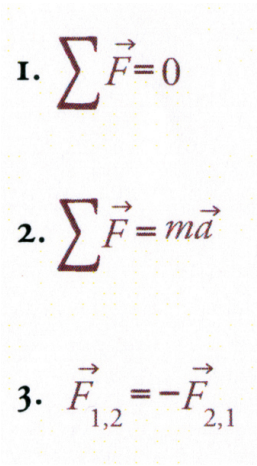
that could be used to predict human choices by quantifying the respective strength of these two forces. He never calculated that 'the force acting on a man is equal to the acceleration of his spirit divided by the mass of his body'.

This is exactly what scientists seek to accomplish. In 1687, Isaac Newton published *The Mathematical Principles of Natural Philosophy*, arguably the most important book in modern history. Newton presented a general theory of movement and change. The greatness of Newton's theory was its ability to explain and predict the movements of all bodies in the universe, from falling apples to shooting stars, using three very simple mathematical laws:



Henceforth, anyone who wished to understand and predict the movement of a cannonball or a planet simply had to make measurements of the object's mass, direction and acceleration, and the forces acting on it. By inserting these numbers into Newton's equations, the future position of the object could be predicted. It worked like magic. Only around the end of the nineteenth century did scientists come across a few observations that did not fit well with Newton's laws, and these led to the next revolutions in physics – the theory of relativity and quantum mechanics.

Newton showed that the book of nature is written in the language of mathematics. Some chapters (physics, for example) boil down to clear-cut equations; but scholars who attempted to reduce biology, economics and psychology to neat Newtonian equations have discovered that these fields have a level of complexity that makes such an aspiration futile. This did not mean, however, that they gave up on mathematics. A new branch of